

English 101: Fundamentals of College Composition

I. The Writing Process

Pre-Writing

- **Brainstorming:** Generating initial ideas through free writing, mind mapping, or listing
- **Research:** Gathering relevant information from credible sources
- **Thesis Development:** Creating a focused central argument that guides the entire piece

Drafting

- **Outline:** Organizing ideas in a logical structure
- **Topic Sentences:** Opening sentences that present the main idea of each paragraph
- **Supporting Evidence:** Facts, examples, or quotes that reinforce the thesis

Revision

- **Content Evaluation:** Assessing the strength and relevance of arguments
- **Organization:** Ensuring logical flow between ideas
- **Coherence:** Maintaining consistent focus throughout the piece

II. Essay Structure

Introduction

- **Hook:** Opening statement that captures reader's attention
- **Context:** Background information about the topic
- **Thesis Statement:** Clear presentation of the paper's main argument

Body Paragraphs

- **Topic Sentence:** States the main idea of the paragraph
- **Supporting Evidence:** Details that develop the topic sentence
- **Analysis:** Explanation of how evidence supports the thesis
- **Transitions:** Words or phrases that connect ideas between paragraphs

Conclusion

- **Thesis Restatement:** Restating the main argument in fresh words
- **Summary:** Brief recap of main points
- **Closing Statement:** Final thoughts that leave a lasting impression

III. Grammar and Mechanics

Parts of Speech

- **Noun:** Person, place, thing, or idea
- **Verb:** Action or state of being
- **Adjective:** Word that describes a noun
- **Adverb:** Word that modifies a verb, adjective, or other adverb
- **Pronoun:** Word that replaces a noun
- **Preposition:** Word that shows relationship between words

Sentence Structure

- **Independent Clause:** Complete thought with subject and verb
- **Dependent Clause:** Incomplete thought that relies on an independent clause
- **Compound Sentence:** Two independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction
- **Complex Sentence:** Independent clause plus one or more dependent clauses

Common Punctuation

- **Period (.):** Ends a complete sentence
- **Comma (,):** Separates elements in a series or joins independent clauses
- **Semicolon (;):** Joins related independent clauses
- **Colon (:):** Introduces a list or explanation

IV. Research Skills

Source Evaluation

- **Currency:** How recent is the information?
- **Relevance:** How well does it relate to your topic?
- **Authority:** Who is the author/publisher?
- **Accuracy:** Can the information be verified?

Citation Styles

- **MLA:** Modern Language Association format, commonly used in humanities
- **APA:** American Psychological Association format, used in social sciences
- **Chicago:** Chicago Manual of Style, used in various disciplines

Plagiarism Prevention

- **Direct Quotation:** Using exact words with proper citation
- **Paraphrasing:** Restating ideas in your own words
- **Common Knowledge:** Information that doesn't require citation